

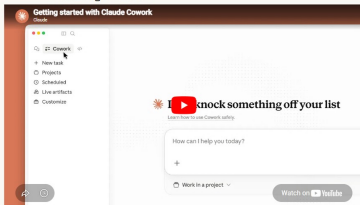
Estimated time: 15 minutes

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson you'll be able to:

- Walk a Cowork task end-to-end through delegation, mid-task steering, and final review
- Respond to Cowork's clarifying questions in a way that produces better output
- Course-correct when Claude heads in the wrong direction

Watch one go end-to-end



This video walks through a single, real piece of work from delegation to deliverable: the prompt, the clarifying questions Claude asks, the moment the user reroutes mid-task, and the finished result at the end. Notice the rhythm — it's less like prompting a chatbot and more like briefing a smart colleague who's about to disappear into a task and come back with something done.

Key takeaways

- Claude asks before it commits. Most non-trivial tasks start with a clarifying question or two. The questions are how Claude closes context gaps before the work starts, not friction in the way.
- You can steer mid-task. If Claude is heading in the wrong direction, jump in. You don't have to wait for it to finish and start over.
- The finished deliverable is the artifact, not the chat. Claude makes changes to the files on your computer. Your job at the end is to review it the way you'd review a colleague's work.

Delegate your first task

You picked a task in previous lessons. Now is when it leaves your plate. Open Cowork, point it at the folder where the context for the task lives, turn on any connectors that hold relevant context for the task, and write your prompt.

A good Cowork prompt does three things:

- Names the deliverable. "A one-page brief," "a slide for the QBR," "a ranked list with notes per candidate." Specifies about format and length save you a regenerate.
- Names the inputs. Which folder, which channels, which date range, which application. Cowork is only as good as the context you point it at.
- Names additional specifics or nuances Claude would need to get the job done. "I want to see base, best, and worst case scenarios that also account for the 3 new locations we opened in Q1 last year." That sentence directs Claude on the type of output you're looking for, and provides key insights from your expertise that Claude might not see.

Build an example Cowork prompt in the interactive below.

BUILD THE PROMPT

RECOMMEND

your page name

slide for the QBR

email it with notes

INPUTS

Q1 Completed Review folder

all quarter's memos as formal reference

email on PDFs only

NOTES

for the executive team at the leadership office — help them decide at the new pricing for

ask with the recommendation

flag anything we can't verify

Write a message...

Ask

Cancel

Leave a row empty and Cowork will usually ask you for it.

If you're used to prompting a chatbot, this will feel like more upfront work — it is. The trade is that more of the back-and-forth happens upfront, before Claude starts, instead of across five rounds of "actually, can you also..."

Answer the clarifying questions

Claude asks questions to clarify any ambiguities about your objectives before it gets into the work. In Chat, you collaborate as you go — context shows up turn by turn. In Cowork, you delegate and it returns with a completed artifact. Anything that might trip it up — any gaps in its understanding — comes up through the questions before it dives in.

Most are easy: Claude presents a couple of options and you click the one that fits. If none of the options fit, you can answer in your own words.

Below are some examples of the questions you might receive from Cowork after submitting the prompt you built above.

COWORK IS ASKING YOU A FEW THINGS

I see two memos in this folder — Q2 board memos.docx and Q2 board memo-FINAL.docx. Which should I match?

Q2 board memo-FINAL.docx (Recommended)

Q2 board memos.docx

Either — they're close enough

Something else

Skip

to navigate

to select

to skip

Pick an answer to see what I tell Claude.

Steer mid-task

Watch Cowork's plan and progress as it works. If it's going off track — wrong source, wrong format, wrong tone — interrupt. You can also stop the run if it's substantially off, refine the prompt, and start again with what you've learned. Most people's instinct from Chat is to wait until the response is done and then regenerate. Resist that. Cowork is built for course corrections, and the cost of a redirect is low.

Steer the example task below and see how Claude responds.

STEER MID-TASK

Help me draft the Q2 completed memo for the leadership office.

IT read the end-of-all PDFs and last quarter's memos, cross-references with competitor pricing changes against our positioning notes, then draft against the Q2 board memo template.

Board memo, scheduled 3 slides - 1.1 Writing draft section 2 of 4

Write a message...

Cancel

Steer

Progress

Load source PDFs and last quarter's memos

Cross-reference pricing changes

Outline three competitive memos

Drafting against Q2 board memo template

Review against original prompt

Review the finished deliverable

When Claude is done, you can preview the file in the app. The file is also in your folder, so you can open it up and see it there.

Review it the way you'd read a draft from someone you trust but don't yet fully know — with your discernment turned on. Things to check, especially the first few times:

- Does it meet the actual objective? Or did it produce something subtly different from what you asked for?
- Are the facts accurate? If Claude references facts or figures, confirm they're correct by reviewing the source material. Start by asking Claude to identify the docs it pulled from, then check them yourself.
- Does anything sound made-up? A specific date, name, or quote that you can't trace to an input is a flag, not a feature.

If the draft is mostly right, tell Claude what to change rather than starting over. Claude remembers the conversation and edits faster than it regenerates.

If the draft is wrong in a load-bearing way, the prompt was missing the load-bearing piece of context. Point Claude to the new context and ask it to make adjustments.

Try it now

Take the task you identified in Lesson 3 — or pick one now. Hand it to Cowork using the process you just walked through — name the deliverable, the inputs, and any nuance; answer the clarifying questions specifically; steer if it drifts; review the result with your discernment on. The first run is the one that teaches you the most.

What's next

You've now done it once. In Module 2, you'll start making Cowork yours — keeping the context that worked, the workflows you want repeated, and the expertise your team relies on, so you don't re-supply it every time you start a task.

Feedback

As you progress through the course, we'd love to hear how you're using concepts from it in your work, plus any feedback you may have. Share your feedback here.

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